

Monica Kumaran
Mr. Raymond Novak
English 101
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My Letter to Mr. Novak

Mr. Novak touched my family and I's lives in a profound way. We knew nothing about American culture. We are first generation immigrants from another country.

The humanities education he gave us was from a master of the craft. It was a deeply fulfilling experience to grow under his tutelage for three years. It planted the seed in me as a child - you treat kids as adults, including you're angry when they disappoint you. Reflection and writing is important, getting up and looking something up for accuracy is important, books are beautiful, you speak up when something is wrong, everyone gets a chance and a fair turn to shine.

His introduction to Mark Twain and both Huck Finn and Tom Sawyer's books, Scout in How To Kill A Mockingbird, paying attention to the women in the Shakespearean plays as people too, Cyrano, Jekyll and Hyde, and a Tell-tale heart by Edgar Allen Poe were truly good. I repeated books in high school, and the teachers did not have his level of depth in understanding and students mostly used online sites for ideas. Without an education like his, I may really have thought this was the pinnacle of thought.

Mr. Novak's diligent uncounted hours at his craft gave us a boon in life that doesn't exist for many people doing the right thing at the right place. He had a

way of standing at the podium, quietly smiling a kind yet slightly intimidating smile, and daring us to meet the great challenges and moral quandaries posed by the high school level AP books he decided to assign to middle schoolers. He may have been amazingly kind and full of agape [refer to “seven types of love found by Greek philosophers” for definition of agape and other forms of love] love, but he was in no way weak.

There is more to add to this story.

Mr. Novak was not always perfect.

His approach to English literature was to come in every day and play a full contact sport, even as a man in his sixties. He had skin in the game. At the lectern, he came there expecting us all to rise to the challenge. He gave me higher standards around relationships, a role model, and an outlet.

One time he gave us all a pro and con essay on humans posing as zoo animals for a day for publicizing and helping the animals, and we all except one person said yes it is good. He called us all parrots and praised the one dissenter- you don't know anything about being a zoo animal, you're taking advantage of their situation for attention and ditching the next day. You are a pretend zoo animal, not a real zoo animal, and have no empathy for what the entire life is truly like.

I believe Mr. Novak was a private man to students. I did not know he was a poet and creator until his church mentioned after his passing. He never gave a hint of his true beliefs and likings as a poet, or even mentioned he was a practitioner of the craft.

The hints I got on his authorial taste was I think he loved Robert Frost. He relished the line about how birch trees catapulted boys "Like girls on hands and knees that throw their hair" As a girl, I was truly baffled on why this was noteworthy. I think he loved game shows. He may have admired Kubla Khan by Samuel Taylor Coleridge quite a bit, as well as mystery stories, such as Sherlock and the speckled snake.

I don't know if he ever told the ones closest to him his real full set of philosophies and beliefs. He penned the quote - "The purpose in life is not to experience happiness, but wonder". (I thought it was hokey for the longest time, until I actually stepped out of my bubble into the real world). He had a phase where he proclaimed the class was "Novakian Universe" and had a rainbow tie dye decorative wall cloth phase. I felt that giving AP English literature books to middle schoolers, even the Count of Monte Cristo and the Scarlet Pimpernel, was itself kind of a radical hippie experiment to teach children right from wrong and to love life and think of others, before being tested in high school and after graduation from K-12.

I believe his favorite day of class was the day we started a new book. Big fat, perfect books were passed across the front row, and then distributed backwards down the column to the end of the classroom, each student taking groups of books, taking one, and passing it along. The end effect was as if a set of tiny, fuzzy, very determined caterpillars was doing its everyday business of unfurling. Personally, my favorite days were the ones where we stapled our work all together on the board, both the rough and final drafts of our essays, and were given time to float around and check out everyone else's ideas, be together, and be proud of our hard work. We stapled our essays side by side, with the rough draft on the back and the final draft on the front.

It's hard to pin down great humanitarians and thinkers like Mr. Novak. In a way they are chameleons showing an aspect of themselves most similar to the person they care about.

I waited all these extra years to write this letter, because I was waiting to grow up fully. I wanted to do it justice.

Mr. Novak, I don't know what it meant to truly know you, but you had a world of hidden nature, beauty, and wonder hidden inside you, and secretly, deep down, you knew it.

You saved me years of my life wilting, uncelebrated for being a fish walking up a tree. Your expectations were stratospheric most of the time, but you did something magical for us students. Through me you may have taught my parents something about how to act too and this culture of service.

Most likely you made something larger out of something smaller that was given to you by just a bit.

You led a life of dignity in any circumstance. You took the artist path and followed it right through to the end, and I hope you know that just your redefinition of what it means to be a teacher is jawdropping.

You didn't have to go look at us like little outcomes and worry every time we cut a corner or were mean to each other. You were an outcome too.

You showed us something that we may not always see in our lifetimes- a fully actualized man at peace with everything in his life, despite the particulars. The old giving the young a gift that will save them from serious harm if they listen and

take it seriously. A meaningful existence beyond material things; a small connection to the inner wildness that created the great pillars our society stands on.

Mr. Novak, you thought way too hard about us. I want you to know you were the biggest overachiever in terms of teaching English literature, so it's not just us overachieving and you railing against our middle school overachiever complexes.

Most importantly than anything I said in this essay is this- you changed the world just by existing, in the best possible way. To me, you were one of the greatest teachers I'd ever had the honor to meet. Thank you.

Sincerely,
Monica Kumaran

[Raymond Novak Obituary \(2013\) - Chicago, IL - Chicago Sun-Times](#)